

Kate Izsak - Artist's Statement

Call for Art for “Rich with Love – A Decade of Remembrance”

The Patriotics of Hate

Data sculpture/digital video, 2026

This piece is a computational data sculpture created by animating a large dataset on hate crimes. The data visualization is composited with an image 1st Lt. Richard W. Collins from the plaque memorializing his murder.

Positionality

I am a digital and computational process artist, as well as a Principal Lecturer and Associate Dean in the College of Information, where I teach courses on storytelling, entertainment design, and computational image design. I use data, code, digital imaging, and procedural systems as materials for reflection. My work is less about producing a single finished image than it is about designing a process through which meaning is generated: gathering data, assigning visual rules, translating categories into color and scale, and then questioning the ethical limits of that translation. In this project, computation becomes a way to examine how violence is recorded, classified, remembered, and made visible.

Perhaps most importantly, I acknowledge that I am a white woman attempting to abstract and capture a piece of a Black man's life. I have attempted to approach this project with humility and respect. I hope I have succeeded.

Personal Statement

I experienced the murder of Richard Collins indirectly, but nonetheless powerfully. At the time, I was working closely with a group of undergraduate students creating a project for a Facebook competition. The competition asked student groups to develop social media campaigns that would educate their peers about the prevention of targeted violence. I was working late nights with these students while they implemented their campaign. Only days before the students were to present to an international audience, Collins was murdered. Late that night, I discovered that two of these students were the murderer's roommates. I spent even longer nights talking with them as they tried to process his crime and reconcile it with the person they thought they knew. They had to do this while feeling that they did not have the right to mourn the loss of their friend—not killed, but incarcerated—or, more painfully, the loss of certainty that they had ever truly known him.

I also noticed a preoccupation with the notion of hate crimes on campus. While Collins's killer was not ultimately convicted of a hate crime, his trial revolved around both murder and hate crime accusations. In class conversations across different contexts, I noticed that the term "hate crime" was both familiar and opaque. Students often recognized its emotional and political force, but were less certain about how a hate crime is legally defined, how that designation is established, who has the authority to name it, and why the category can feel both necessary and insufficient. At UMD, the concept of the hate crime became part of the public imagination surrounding Collins' murder: a way of naming racialized violence, but also a site of uncertainty, grief, debate, and institutional reckoning.

Process

This project begins with a difficult question: how can data be used to approach a human life without reducing that life to numbers, symbols, or abstraction? No dataset, map, timeline, or visual system can contain the fullness of his life, his relationships, his promise, or the grief carried by those who love him. Data appears in the work not as a way to quantify Richard Collins, but as a way to make visible the systems that surround his story: institutional memory, public documentation, spatial context, patterns of attention, and the ways racial violence is recorded or remembered

I used fireworks to animate data on hate crimes in the United States in 2017. Fireworks suggest celebration, national ritual, and patriotism; they are associated with belonging, public joy, and the symbolic performance of Americanness. But fireworks are also dangerous explosions. In this project, that tension matters. Lt. Collins was a young Black man, a Bowie State student, and a commissioned Army officer preparing to serve his country. The language of patriotism cannot be separated from the reality of the racial violence that ended his life. Fireworks therefore become an unstable symbol: not simply a sign of national pride, but a question about who is protected by the nation, who is asked to serve it, and whose humanity is fully recognized within it.

I chose to keep Richard Collins's portrait stable and recognizable while placing movement, color, and light around him. This was important because I wanted the piece to preserve his identity rather than transform him into an abstract visual element. The animated effects create an atmosphere of memory, grief, honor, and continued presence, but they do not overtake his face or make him less legible as a person. By allowing the visual energy to surround him rather than alter him, I tried to balance experimentation with respect. The goal was to create a piece that feels alive and emotionally expressive while still centering Collins's dignity, individuality, and humanity.

Data

I chose to work with a dataset from the FBI Uniform Crime Reporting Program on race-related hate crimes in the year of Collins's murder. In 2017, the FBI collected data from 16,149 law

enforcement agencies and the result was a reported 7,175 hate crime incidents involving 8,437 offenses.¹ I animated the data focused specifically on racially motivated hate crimes.

I recognize that hate crime data reported through law enforcement agencies is incomplete and shaped by many factors: whether victims report, whether police recognize an incident as bias-motivated, whether agencies participate in reporting, and how cases are classified and convictions are adjudicated. These limitations are part of the meaning of the work rather than a flaw I am trying to hide. My goal was not to create a definitive statistical account of hate in 2017, but to work with the official record as one imperfect measure of the national climate in the year Richard Collins was murdered. The data offer a general picture of reported hate violence, while their gaps (perhaps the spaces between the explosions) point to the many harms that remain unseen, unreported, misclassified, or unresolved.

Abstraction Legend

Firework Timing

Fireworks go off in the order that race-based hate crimes were committed during 2017. The full year is 3 minutes long.

Firework Size

Firework size represents the scale of the violence of each incident.

Size	Violence Intensity
Small	Threat, intimidation, symbolic aggression
Medium	Escalation, confrontation, documented physical harm
Large	Severe or fatal violence, including acts that result in death, extreme bodily harm, and/or lasting community trauma

Firework Colors

The colors of the fireworks represent the targeted racial group for each incident.

Color Name	Hex Code	Thumb	Targeted Racial Group
------------	----------	-------	-----------------------

¹ The DOJ/FBI data includes information about offenses, victims, offenders, locations, and bias motivations. Race, ethnicity, and ancestry bias was the largest single-bias category in 2017, accounting for 58.1% of single-bias incidents. Within the race/ethnicity/ancestry category, the largest number of reported incidents were anti-Black or anti-African American bias incidents: 2,013 incidents involving 2,458 victims. Other major racial or ethnic bias categories included anti-Hispanic or anti-Latino incidents with 427 incidents involving 552 victims, anti-Other Race/Ethnicity/Ancestry incidents with 270 incidents involving 322 victims, anti-American Indian or Alaska Native incidents with 251 incidents involving 321 victims, and anti-Multiracial, with 180 incidents involving 229 victims. Smaller but still significant categories included anti-Asian incidents with 131 incidents involving 165 victims, anti-Arab incidents with 102 incidents involving 131 victims, and anti-Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander incidents with 16 incidents involving 18 victims.

		-nail	
Green Gas	#00ff99		Anti-Black/African American Hate Crimes
Laser Lemon	#ffff66		Anti-Hispanic/Latino Hate Crimes
Beaming Blue	#33ffff		Anti-Arab Hate Crimes
Electric Red	#e60000		Anti-Asian Hate Crimes
Limoncello	#bfff00		Anti-American Indian or Alaska Native Hate Crimes
Lán Sè Blue	#4d4dff		Anti-Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander Hate Crimes
Piquant Pink	#e600e6		Anti-White Hate Crimes
Vitamin C	#ff9900		Anti-Multiracial Hate Crimes
Trusted Purple	#6600cc		Anti-Other Race/Ethnicity/Ancestry